group forward. Explaining why he chose Mistry to head the Tata empire despite JRD's disdain for Pallonji, Ratan says that Mistry's British education had blinded him. Mistry was an alumnus of the Imperial College, London, and London Business School. 'I naively thought' that the 'DNA' of a person with such an impressive education would be different, he says.

He publicly and enthusiastically endorsed Mistry's appointment in a press statement released on 23 November 2011 by Tata Sons. This was done to reassure the new chairman and send a clear message to all the companies that he had Ratan's full backing. The release quoted Ratan as saying: 'The appointment of Mr Cyrus P. Mistry as Deputy Chairman of Tata Sons is a good and far-sighted choice. He has been on the Board of Tata Sons since August 2006 and I have been impressed with the quality and caliber [sic] of his participation, his astute observations and his humility. He is intelligent and qualified to take on the responsibility being offered and I will be committed to working with him over the next year to give him the exposure, the involvement and the operating experience to equip him to undertake the full responsibility of the Group on my retirement.'

Ratan lost virtually no opportunity to voice his support for his successor. About five months before he stepped down, while addressing the 2012 AGMM, he spoke in glowing terms about Mistry: 'It has been a joy to work with him … He is his own person.' He is 'remarkably able to grasp business issues', will take the group to 'new heights' and 'is the right person for [the] job', Ratan added. In conclusion, he said that he would 'look at the group from a distance', and told the senior functionaries: 'Hope that you will give Cyrus the same support … that I have had the pleasure to have.'

Ratan's support for Mistry had begun much before the events described, since the time he was chairman of Tata Power and Mistry a member of the board. The most remarkable instance of his backing Mistry was when the question of finding a successor to Pallonji on the board of Tata Sons came up in 2006.

Pallonji was keen to appoint Cyrus Mistry's older sibling, Shapoor, in his place. But Ratan had other plans. He made clear his preference for Cyrus, asserting that he would contribute more as a director of Tata Sons than his brother. Pallonji persisted in backing Shapoor. But Ratan stuck to his stand, stating that Pallonji could not demand to be represented on the board as a matter of right, much less decide who would be on it. Consequently, the Mistrys went unrepresented in the board of Tata Sons for about twenty